CHAPTER 11

# SOCIAL MOVEMENTS

**CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:**
Examine collective mobilization and social movements in India, studying Aberle's typology, Old versus New Social Movements, peasant and farmer mobilizations, tribal struggles, Dalit Panthers, contemporary women's activism, and grassroots environmental conservation.

## 4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **Sociological Anatomy of Social Movements:** A social movement is a sustained, collective effort to bring about or prevent social change, characterized by shared ideology, collective identity, organizational structure, leadership, and public protest repertoires rather than spontaneous riots.

• **Aberle's Typology and New Social Movements:** David Aberle classified social movements into Redemptive (individual transformation), Reformist (gradual legislative change), and Revolutionary (total overhaul of state and society); New Social Movements (NSMs) focus on post-materialist identity, human dignity, ecological sustainability, and decentralization.

• **Agrarian, Tribal, and Dalit Assertions:** Subaltern movements span historical peasant uprisings (Tebhaga, Telangana), New Farmer Movements fighting state procurement terms (BKU, Shetkari Sanghatana), tribal resource struggles (Jharkhand movement), and militant Dalit assertion (Dalit Panthers in Maharashtra).

• **Feminist and Ecological Grassroots Mobilization:** Autonomous women's movements transformed legal frameworks on dowry, rape, and domestic violence; ecological movements (Chipko, Appiko, Narmada Bachao Andolan, Silent Valley) redefined development as ecological sustainability and survival rights.

## ESSENTIAL SOCIOLOGICAL CONCEPTS & INSTITUTIONS

$$\text{Aberle Movement Typology} \rightarrow \{\text{Redemptive: Personal Salvation}, \quad \text{Reformist: Institutional Adjustment}, \quad \text{Revolutionary: Systemic Overthrow}\}$$

*Three-Tier Classical Classification of Social Movements*

$$\text{Movement Paradigms} \rightarrow \{\text{Old Movements: Class, Wages, and State Capture}, \quad \text{New Movements: Identity, Ecology, and Human Dignity}\}$$

*Structural Evolution from Materialist to Post-Materialist Struggles*

$$\text{Ecological Resistance} \iff \text{Livelihood Defense} + \text{Indigenous Forest Rights} \rightarrow \text{Challenge to Destructive Megaprojects}$$

*Environmentalism of the Poor Paradigm*

$$\text{Dalit Panther Mobilization} \iff \text{Subaltern Literary Assertion} + \text{Militant Counter-Culture} \rightarrow \text{Constitutional Dignity Claim}$$

*Radical Cultural and Political Transformation Dynamic*

## CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** Do not confuse a spontaneous riot or protest gathering with a social movement; a social movement requires sustained organizational continuity, shared ideology, and long-term programmatic mobilization.

• **Alert:** New Farmer Movements in the late 1970s and 1980s (e.g., BKU in UP, Shetkari Sanghatana in Maharashtra) differed from pre-independence peasant movements: they mobilized market-oriented farmers around remunerative crop prices, electricity subsidies, and state procurement rates.

• **Alert:** The Chipko Movement was not merely a romantic tree-hugging exercise; it was an economic and ecological struggle by Himalayan village women defending local forest ecosystems against commercial logging contractors.

## HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

### 1. Define a social movement and list two of its essential features. [Score: 2 Marks]

**Answer & Key Valuation Steps:**

• **Definition:** A social movement is a sustained, organized collective effort by a group of people directed towards bringing about or resisting fundamental changes in society. **[1 Mark]**

• **Two Essential Features:** Presence of an identifiable leadership and organizational structure, and sustained collective mobilization guided by a shared ideology. **[1 Mark]**

### 2. Differentiate between reformist social movements and revolutionary social movements with examples. [Score: 3 Marks]

**Answer & Key Valuation Steps:**

• **Reformist Movements:** Seek to change specific institutional practices, laws, or social norms within the existing political and social order through democratic protests and legal advocacy (e.g. Right to Information movement, anti-dowry movement). **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Revolutionary Movements:** Aim at the complete and radical overthrow of existing political power structures and property relations (e.g. Bolshevik Revolution of 1917, Naxalbari movement). **[1.5 Marks]**

### 3. How do 'New Social Movements' differ from 'Old Social Movements'? [Score: 4 Marks]

**Answer & Key Valuation Steps:**

• **Central Objective:** Old movements focused primarily on class conflict, economic redistribution, wages, and capturing state power through trade unions and political parties. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Focus of New Movements:** New Social Movements focus on post-materialist concerns: personal and cultural identity, environmental sustainability, gender dignity, and human rights. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Organizational Form:** Old movements are centralized and bureaucratic; New movements are decentralized, networked, and rely on non-party civil society grassroots action. **[1 Mark]**

### 4. Explain the historical background and significance of the Chipko Movement in Uttarakhand. [Score: 4 Marks]

**Answer & Key Valuation Steps:**

• **Historical Background:** Began in 1973 in the Chamoli district of Uttarakhand when local Himalayan villagers, particularly women led by Gaura Devi, clung to trees to prevent commercial timber contractors from felling them. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Ecological and Economic Core:** It was an environmentalism of the poor; villagers depended on local broad-leaved oak forests for fuel, fodder, and soil retention, which commercial clear-felling was destroying. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **National Significance:** Forced the central government to impose a 15-year moratorium on commercial logging in the Himalayan region and inspired grassroots eco-movements across India like Appiko. **[1 Mark]**

### 5. Discuss the origins, ideology, and impact of the Dalit Panthers movement in Maharashtra. [Score: 4 Marks]

**Answer & Key Valuation Steps:**

• **Origins:** Formed in Bombay in 1972 by young Dalit writers and activists (Namdeo Dhasal, Arjun Dangle, J.V. Pawar) inspired by Dr. B.R. Ambedkar and the Black Panther Party in the United States. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Ideology and Counter-Culture:** Rejected passive accommodation, defining 'Dalit' broadly to include all exploited classes (scheduled castes, landless labourers, poor peasants, women); unleashed revolutionary Dalit literature. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Impact:** Physically confronted caste atrocities in rural Maharashtra, compelled the state to enforce constitutional safeguards, and laid the groundwork for the Prevention of Atrocities Act (1989). **[1 Mark]**

**6. Contrast the pre-independence peasant struggles (such as Tebhaga and Telangana) with the post-1970s New Farmer Movements. [Score: 4 Marks]**

**Answer & Key Valuation Steps:**

• **Pre-Independence Struggles:** Directed against feudal landlords and colonial revenue extraction; fought for land to the tiller, reduction of extortionate crop rents (two-thirds share in Tebhaga), and abolition of forced labour. **[2 Marks]**

• **Post-1970s New Farmer Movements:** Led by market-oriented farmers (such as Bharatiya Kisan Union in UP and Shetkari Sanghatana in Maharashtra); focused on terms of trade against the state, demanding remunerative crop procurement prices, subsidized electricity and diesel, and debt waivers. **[2 Marks]**

**7. Highlight the major issues championed by the autonomous women's movement in India from the 1970s onwards. [Score: 4 Marks]**

**Answer & Key Valuation Steps:**

• **Autonomous Character:** Formed independent feminist groups not affiliated with male-dominated political parties, asserting that 'the personal is political'. **[1 Mark]**

• **Violence Against Women:** Campaigned vigorously against custodial rape (sparked by the 1978 Mathura rape case), leading to major amendments in the Indian Penal Code and Evidence Act. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Domestic Abuse and Dowry Murders:** Street plays, public protests, and legal advocacy forced Parliament to enact strict laws against dowry harassment (Section 498A) and pass the Protection of Women from Domestic Violence Act (2005). **[1.5 Marks]**